

How to Increase Your Tips and Income

A server and bartender playbook for bigger checks, better sections, and more money in your pocket every shift

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- The tip formula and the three levers that raise it
- Greeting and table-reading strategies
- Upsell scripts that don't feel pushy
- 30-day growth plan and shift income tracker

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Proven table-side habits, upsell scripts, and a 30-day income tracker

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CHAPTER 1

Why Some Servers Make More

Two servers can work the same restaurant, the same night, with the same menu, and walk out with very different money. The gap is rarely luck. It usually comes down to a handful of habits you can learn: how you open the table, how you guide the order, how you time the check, and how you make guests feel remembered.

This guide breaks those habits into small steps you can practice one shift at a time. You don't need a new personality or a pushy sales style. The servers who earn the most are usually the ones guests trust.

The tip formula

Most tips follow a simple equation:

$$\text{Tip} = \text{Check Size} \times \text{Tip Percentage} \times \text{Number of Tables You Turn}$$

That gives you three levers to pull:

- **Check size.** Suggest items that make the meal better, like an appetizer, a second drink, or dessert to share.
- **Tip percentage.** Make the experience feel personal, attentive, and easy.
- **Table turns.** Be efficient without rushing people, so you serve more guests in the same shift.

A small change on each lever adds up fast. Raise your average check by \$6, your average tip by 2%, and your table count by one per shift, and you could earn thousands more a year without working extra hours.

Lever	Small improvement	What it could mean over a year*
Average check	+\$6 per table	+\$1,400 to \$2,000
Tip percentage	18% → 20%	+\$1,800 to \$3,000
Table turns	+1 table per shift	+\$2,000 to \$3,500

*Example estimates for a full-time server averaging about 20 tables a shift. Your numbers will vary by restaurant, price point, and schedule.

Try this: Pick just one lever to focus on this week. Trying to fix everything at once usually means nothing sticks.

CHAPTER 2

The First 60 Seconds

Guests decide how they feel about you within the first minute. A warm, confident greeting sets the tone for the whole meal and makes guests more open to your suggestions.

Greet fast, even if you're slammed

Aim to acknowledge every new table within 60 seconds of seating, even if all you can say is a quick hello. A table left waiting and ignored starts the meal irritated. A table told "Hi folks, I'll be right with you!" starts it patient.

A greeting that works

Skip the robotic script. Try this structure instead:

- **Name:** "Hi, I'm Jordan, and I'll be taking care of you tonight."
- **Read the table:** Are they celebrating? Rushed on a lunch break? On a date? Adjust your energy to match.
- **Lead with a suggestion:** "Have you been in before? Our spicy margarita is what everyone's ordering this week."

Reading the table

Table type	What they want	How to serve them
Business lunch	Speed and no interruptions	Get the order in fast, pre-bus quietly, drop the check without being asked
Date night	Privacy and a little romance	Check in less often, suggest a shared dessert, don't linger
Families with kids	Patience and practical help	Bring crayons and kids' cups early, get the kids' food out first
Celebrations	To feel special	Ask what they're celebrating, remember it, add a candle or a personal touch
Regulars	To be remembered	Use their name, remember their usual order, ask about their life
Solo diners	Comfort without pressure	A friendly check-in, a phone charger if you can, never rush them

Try this: Before you approach, take a breath and smile before you arrive at the table, not when you get there. Guests notice.

CHAPTER 3

Upselling Without Being Pushy

Upselling works best when it's a genuine recommendation. You're not pushing product; you're helping guests have a better meal. Guests who order an appetizer, a nicer bottle, or dessert usually enjoy the experience more, and a bigger check usually means a bigger tip.

Suggest specifics, not categories

"Would you like any appetizers?" is easy to say no to. "The crispy calamari with lemon aioli is perfect for sharing while you look at the menu" paints a picture.

Instead of this	Try this
"Anything to drink?"	"Can I start you with our house sangria? It's made fresh every morning."
"Want an appetizer?"	"Our spinach dip comes out fast and it's big enough for the whole table."
"Any dessert?"	"Save room for our lava cake. Should I bring two spoons or four?"
"Another beer?"	"Want me to bring another round so it's here when your food lands?"
"Do you want to add anything?"	"Most people add shrimp to that pasta; it's only \$6 more."

The upgrade ladder

Look for small, natural upgrades at every step of the meal:

- **Drinks:** premium spirits in cocktails, a bottle instead of glasses for 3+ wine drinkers
- **Starters:** a shareable appetizer while they decide
- **Entrées:** add-on proteins, premium sides, sauces
- **Refills:** a second drink offered before the first is empty
- **Dessert:** shared dessert, coffee, after-dinner drinks
- **To-go:** desserts, sauces, or a bottle of house dressing to take home

Know the menu cold

You can't recommend what you haven't tasted. Ask your manager or kitchen if you can try new items. Learn two or three words that describe each dish: "smoky," "bright," "crispy," "rich." Guests trust servers who speak about food with confidence.

Important: Never pressure a guest who has said no, and never upsell alcohol to someone who shows signs of intoxication. Aggressive selling costs you tips and can put your job or license at risk.

CHAPTER 4

Service Habits That Raise Your Tip Percentage

Anticipate needs

The best service feels like mind-reading. Watch for cues and act before the guest has to ask:

- Refill water before the glass is half empty.
- Bring extra napkins with wings, ribs, or anything messy.
- Offer steak knives before the steak arrives.
- Bring hot sauce, ketchup, or extra sauces with the food, not after.
- Clear finished plates promptly, but never while others are still eating.

The two-bite check-back

Check on the table within two bites or two minutes of the food arriving. It's the moment problems show up: wrong temperature, missing side, wrong order. Fixing it fast turns a potential bad tip into a great one.

Personal touches that pay off

- **Use their name** if it's on a reservation or card. "Thank you, Mrs. Garcia."
- **Remember preferences.** "Extra lemon again?" makes regulars feel valued.
- **Crouch down** to eye level when you're talking with seated guests (if it fits your restaurant's culture). It feels friendly rather than hovering.
- **Write a thank-you** on the check, briefly and sincerely. A quick "Thanks so much, enjoy your night!" is enough.
- **Introduce yourself to regulars** and invite them to request your section next time.

Handling mistakes like a pro

Mistakes happen. How you respond decides the tip. Use the **LAST** method:

- **Listen** without interrupting.
- **Apologize** sincerely: "I'm so sorry about that."
- **Solve** it fast: fix the dish, remake the drink, get a manager if needed.
- **Thank** them for telling you.

Guests often tip more after a well-handled mistake than after a meal where nothing went wrong.

CHAPTER 5

Working Smarter, Not Harder

Consolidate every trip

Never walk empty-handed. Every trip to the kitchen or bar is a chance to drop off a check, refill drinks, or clear a plate. "Full hands in, full hands out" is the oldest rule in the book for a reason.

Prioritize like a pro

When everything is happening at once, use this order:

1. Greet new tables (even briefly)
2. Run hot food that's ready
3. Deliver drinks
4. Take orders
5. Drop and process checks
6. Pre-bus and reset

Time the check right

Holding a check too long frustrates guests who want to leave. Dropping it too early makes them feel rushed. Watch for the signals: plates pushed away, jackets being put on, glances around the room. For business lunches and families with young kids, drop the check with dessert or as soon as the last plate is cleared.

Section strategy

- Ask your manager how sections are assigned and what earns you the busier or better sections.
- Consistently high sales, low comps, and reliability are the usual path to better sections.
- Pick up shifts on high-volume nights (Friday and Saturday dinners, holidays, event nights) when you can.
- Learn which shifts actually earn the most by tracking your money (see the tracker at the end).

CHAPTER 6

Growing Your Income Beyond the Tip Line

Build your regulars

Regulars are your financial base. Treat them like VIPs, remember their details, and let them know which shifts you work. A few loyal regulars can guarantee solid nights even when the room is slow.

Stack your skills

Servers who can bartend, train new hires, or run a shift as a lead usually earn more and get more hours. Ask about:

- Bartending shifts or barback training
- Becoming a trainer (often paid a training bonus or higher rate)
- Private events and catering (often have higher auto-gratuity)
- Wine and spirits certifications (Court of Master Sommeliers intro level, WSET Level 1)

Know your pay rights

- In the U.S., if your employer pays a tipped minimum wage, your tips plus base pay must reach at least the full minimum wage for your hours. If they don't, your employer is supposed to make up the difference.
- Managers and supervisors generally are not allowed to keep any part of employees' tips under federal law.
- Tip pools and tip-outs have specific rules that vary by state. Ask for your restaurant's tip policy in writing.
- Keep your own record of hours and tips. It protects you if a pay dispute ever comes up.

Important: Wage and tip laws vary by state and change over time. Check your state labor department's website or the U.S. Department of Labor Wage and Hour Division for current rules where you work.

Manage the money you make

Cash tips disappear fast. A few simple habits help:

- Put a set amount (even \$10 a shift) into savings before you spend anything.
- Track your income for taxes. Tips are taxable income, and good records protect you.
- Plan for slow seasons by saving extra during busy months.

TOOLKIT

Your 30-Day Tip Growth Plan

Work through one focus area per week. Check each box as you practice it.

Week 1: The first impression

- Greet every table within 60 seconds
- Introduce yourself by name at every table
- Recommend one specific drink at every greeting
- Read each table type and adjust your approach

Week 2: Suggestive selling

- Taste or study three menu items you don't know well
- Use specific, descriptive suggestions instead of yes/no questions
- Offer a second drink before the first is empty
- Suggest dessert at every table (with two spoons!)

Week 3: Service polish

- Do the two-bite check-back at every table
- Anticipate one need per table before the guest asks
- Use the LAST method on any complaint
- Never walk to the kitchen empty-handed

Week 4: Build your base

- Learn the names of at least five regulars
- Invite great guests to request your section
- Track every shift in the income tracker
- Ask your manager one question about moving up (sections, training, bartending)

Worksheet: Shift Income Tracker

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TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Monthly Review

My best shift this month (day, time, section):

My average tip percentage:

My average hourly earnings:

The habit that made the biggest difference:

The habit I still need to work on:

My goal for next month:

Regulars I want to remember (names and details):

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